

CREATE Institutional Values

A Framework for Culture, Character and Conduct

This document defines the five core values that underpin the identity, expectations, and culture of our institution. Each value is accompanied by its behavioural indicators — observable, assessable expressions of that value in everyday professional practice. The five values are: Curious, Rigorous, Enterprising, Authentic, and Thankful.

1. Curious

Embracing the unknown with courage and an open mind.

DEFINITION

Curiosity is the engine of growth. A curious individual does not simply accept the world as it is — they question, probe, and push into unfamiliar territory with deliberate intent. At our institution, curiosity is not passive interest; it is an active, disciplined pursuit of deeper understanding. Curious people take on challenges that are uncertain or risky, not in spite of that uncertainty, but because of it. They are energised by the unknown and treat discomfort as a signal that genuine learning is happening.

WHAT IT REPRESENTS

This value represents intellectual bravery — the willingness to step beyond the edges of one's existing knowledge or role, to ask questions before acting, and to remain open to feedback even when it challenges prior assumptions. It reflects an orientation toward continuous discovery rather than the mere accumulation of credentials or titles.

BEHAVIOURAL INDICATORS

1. Faces new or challenging situations despite the risks involved

Curiosity is demonstrated most clearly when someone chooses to engage with an unfamiliar or high-stakes situation instead of defaulting to the safe or familiar. This is intellectual courage — moving toward uncertainty rather than away from it.

2. Examples clearly show work outside comfort zone

Tangible evidence of stepping beyond what is comfortable or established demonstrates that curiosity is practised, not merely claimed. This includes taking on roles, projects, or challenges where failure is genuinely possible.

3. Pursues an action despite no immediate personal gain

True curiosity is intrinsically motivated. A curious person investigates, learns, or acts not because of an immediate reward, but because the pursuit itself has value. This separates genuine intellectual drive from strategic self-interest.

4. Asks insightful questions prior to taking on a challenge

Before diving in, a curious person maps the territory. They identify what they do not know, seek clarity, and use questions as tools to sharpen their approach — not to delay action, but to act better.

5. Seeks out and accepts feedback from others

Curiosity extends to self-knowledge. A curious person treats feedback as data — valuable information about how their actions land in the world — and actively solicits it rather than waiting for it to arrive.

2. Rigorous

Leaving no stone unturned in the pursuit of excellence.

DEFINITION

Rigour is the commitment to doing things properly — not just adequately. A rigorous person does not stop when a solution appears plausible; they verify, stress-test, and improve until they are confident the work is genuinely sound. At our institution, rigour is not perfectionism for its own sake — it is a professional and ethical obligation to produce work that is reliable, thorough, and built to last. Rigorous people are data-informed, process-minded, and deeply trustworthy in their outputs.

WHAT IT REPRESENTS

This value represents a standard of care and conscientiousness that goes beyond the surface. It reflects a belief that quality matters — that the details of how work is done are inseparable from the value of the work itself. Rigour also means intellectual honesty: being willing to challenge one's own conclusions, seek disconfirming evidence, and improve systems rather than simply repeat them.

BEHAVIOURAL INDICATORS

1. Reviews work extensively, leaving no stone unturned

A rigorous person does not submit first drafts as final products. They review, interrogate, and refine. This indicator reflects the discipline to do the full job rather than the convenient portion of it.

2. Tries to improve the process itself or builds systems that are scalable

Beyond completing individual tasks, rigour means thinking about how the work is done. A rigorous person identifies inefficiencies, proposes improvements, and designs solutions that will hold up at scale — not just in the moment.

3. Seeks out additional perspectives and data to make the best decision

Good decisions require good inputs. A rigorous person does not rely solely on their own knowledge or first instincts — they deliberately gather diverse viewpoints and relevant evidence before committing to a course of action.

4. Critically evaluates metrics and data

Numbers and metrics are not self-explanatory. A rigorous person interrogates data rather than accepting it at face value — questioning methodology, looking for anomalies, and understanding what the numbers do and do not actually tell them.

5. Honours commitments and makes good on promises

Rigour includes reliability. A rigorous person treats their word as a binding commitment — they follow through on what they say they will do, on time and to the standard promised. This builds institutional trust and sets a professional norm.

3. Enterprising

Taking initiative and leading the way to better solutions.

DEFINITION

Being enterprising means not waiting to be told what to do. An enterprising person identifies problems, generates creative solutions, and moves toward resolution — often before others have even recognised that a problem exists. At our institution, an enterprising mindset combines initiative with pragmatism: the drive to take the lead is matched by the discipline to listen, gather ideas widely, and avoid unnecessary complexity. Enterprising people are bias-toward-action thinkers who simplify rather than complicate.

WHAT IT REPRESENTS

This value represents proactive ownership — the belief that one has both the agency and the responsibility to make things better. It is the antithesis of passive compliance. An enterprising orientation means seeing a gap and choosing to fill it, generating options where others see dead ends, and being flexible enough to incorporate feedback into one's approach rather than defending the first idea that emerged.

BEHAVIOURAL INDICATORS

1. Generates new ideas or methods for solving a problem

An enterprising person does not recycle the same approaches indefinitely. When confronted with a problem, they actively generate alternatives — new framings, different methodologies, or creative combinations — and evaluate them objectively.

2. Takes the lead in solving problems

Initiative is the defining characteristic of an enterprising individual. Rather than deferring to others or waiting for direction, they step forward and take responsibility for moving a challenge toward resolution, even when the path is not fully mapped.

3. Listens to feedback and uses it to make improvements

Enterprise without flexibility becomes stubbornness. An enterprising person remains genuinely open to feedback and uses it as a resource to improve their solution — adjusting direction based on new information rather than clinging to their original plan.

4. Avoids unnecessary complexity to simplify the problem

The best solutions are often the simplest ones. An enterprising person resists the temptation to over-engineer and instead seeks the most direct path to a robust outcome — cutting scope, reducing dependencies, and eliminating unnecessary steps.

5. Gathers ideas from a wide variety of sources

Smart initiative starts with wide listening. Before committing to an approach, an enterprising person casts a wide net — consulting diverse stakeholders, reviewing analogous situations, and seeking early-stage inputs that might shape a better solution.

4. Authentic

Leading with honesty, humility, and genuine accountability.

DEFINITION

Authenticity is the courage to be honest — about one's capabilities, one's mistakes, and one's convictions — even when honesty is uncomfortable. An authentic person does not perform competence or pretend certainty. They acknowledge the limits of their knowledge, take genuine responsibility for their shortfalls, and provide honest feedback to others because they respect them enough to do so. At our institution, authenticity is the foundation of trust — without it, collaboration, feedback, and institutional culture all erode.

WHAT IT REPRESENTS

This value represents integrity in the fullest sense: consistency between what one believes, what one says, and what one does. It is the opposite of impression management. An authentic person earns trust not by appearing infallible, but by being transparent,

accountable, and genuinely open to being wrong. This requires both self-awareness and the security to express it without defensiveness.

BEHAVIOURAL INDICATORS

1. Recognises when they are lacking expertise or information in a subject area

Self-awareness is the first form of honesty. An authentic person knows what they do not know — and says so. This prevents overconfidence from becoming a liability and creates space for others who have relevant expertise to contribute.

2. Takes responsibility for shortfalls

When things go wrong, authentic people do not deflect blame or minimise their role. They acknowledge their contribution to a failure, reflect on it, and take concrete action to address it — modelling the accountability they expect of others.

3. Recognises when they are not right and supports the best idea

Intellectual humility is a hallmark of authenticity. An authentic person is able to update their position in light of better evidence or argument — and does so gracefully, championing the best idea regardless of its origin.

4. Provides honest feedback to others even when it is difficult

Authentic people respect others enough to be honest with them. They offer constructive, specific feedback — even when it is uncomfortable — because they believe that candid input is a gift rather than a threat to a relationship.

5. Compassionate and respectful towards others

Authenticity does not mean bluntness without regard for impact. An authentic person delivers honesty within a framework of genuine care and respect — understanding that how something is said is as important as what is said.

5. Thankful

Grounded in gratitude, generosity of spirit, and shared success.

DEFINITION

Being thankful is not simply a matter of manners — it is a deeply held orientation toward the world that shapes how one works, leads, and grows. A thankful person recognises that their opportunities, achievements, and capabilities are not solely self-generated. They have been shaped by mentors, institutions, colleagues, and circumstances — and they carry that recognition into how they engage with others. At our institution, thankfulness is paired with generosity: the desire to share what one has learned so that others can benefit.

WHAT IT REPRESENTS

This value represents humility, perspective, and a sense of collective responsibility. It is the antidote to entitlement and the foundation of a genuinely collegiate culture. A thankful person does not hoard knowledge, credit, or opportunity. They attribute success honestly, remain curious even after achieving results, and are motivated by a desire to leave things better than they found them — for peers, for the institution, and for the wider world.

BEHAVIOURAL INDICATORS

1. Grateful for the opportunities and accessibility they have been given

A thankful person holds a clear-eyed awareness of the advantages, relationships, and platforms that have contributed to their development. This gratitude motivates them to use those opportunities well and to extend them to others where possible.

2. Does not feel entitled

Entitlement is the enemy of growth and collaboration. A thankful person earns their place, does not assume privilege, and approaches every role and opportunity as something to be honoured through effort — not a given to be taken for granted.

3. Selflessness and the desire to positively impact the world by sharing learnings with others

Thankfulness manifests as generosity. A thankful person actively shares what they have learned — through mentorship, documentation, teaching, or simply making time for others — because they understand that knowledge shared compounds in value.

4. Keen on learning from others despite successful outcomes

Success can be a barrier to growth if it breeds complacency. A thankful person remains genuinely curious and open to input even after achieving results — recognising that there is always something more to learn from the people around them.

5. Acknowledges the work of others that contributed to their success

A thankful person gives credit generously and publicly. They name the people and conditions that enabled their success — not as a formality, but as a genuine expression of how they understand their own achievements in context.